STRIKING THE RIGHT NOTES

Tabla maestro **Bickram Ghosh** on receiving the Sangeet Natak Akademi Award, his fusion music and movie scores

Q. Congratulations on receiving the Akademi Puraskar. What does this prestigious recognition mean to you?
All artists desire their country's validation. This is India's highest music award, and I am extremely honoured to have been bestowed with it. Also, winning it for contemporary music validates the ambit of my work as a tabla player, fusion music artist and film composer.

Q. People look to artists to be fearless and speak their minds. Are creative people becoming more cautious these days?
I'm never mum. Here's my take—*Ketetakater-eketetakadhagina dha*!

Q. The music of Arindam Sil's *Maayakumari* takes you to the '50s and '60s. Is old always gold?
I love scoring for period films. Today, there is a distinct lack of beautiful, simple melodies, of evocative instrumentation. My work in cinema tries to fill that gap, and the validation I have received tells me that we are a country with a heart of gold. In that, we certainly are 'old'!

Q. The tabla player has always been considered to be an accompanist, the second man. You're the frontman of your outfit. Is that a personal statement?
Yes, it is. I believe the tabla is an incredibly versatile drum, and in the two decades of my band Rhythmscape being around, I've proved that a tabla player can take the centre stage.

with Romita Datta

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